PocketToons: why MAU grew 20% QoQ while revenue stayed flat

Nov 9, 2026 · @Soum · Independent-mode investigation, Product Analytics Agent

Executive answer

The premise holds, and the gap is explained by who the new active users are. Average monthly MAU rose 20.0% from Q2 to Q3 2026 (9,015.7 to 10,818.7). Net revenue rose 0.07% ($30,145.00 to $30,166.97). Revenue is about 99% a $9.99 monthly subscription paid by a steady base of roughly 1,000 subscribers, and that base did not grow.

- **What we observed.** All of the net MAU gain came from users who signed up in Q3 (+3,457 average monthly active), mostly acquired through paid_social. Over the same period, existing users fell by 1,654. Paying users averaged 1,036 a month in both quarters, and ARPPU stayed near $9.70. So MAU and revenue measure different populations.
- **Why new users did not add revenue.** Q3 signups engage with free content as much as Q2 signups did: about 3.6 views and 32 minutes in their first 30 days. But very few of them reach a paywall: 0.5–1.0% saw one in their first 30 days, versus 2.7–4.4% in May–June. 30-day paid conversion fell from 1.94% (May–June cohorts) to 0.53% (July–August cohorts), and it fell within every acquisition source.
- **What this does not prove.** The data shows *where* conversion broke (new users rarely reach the paywall), not *why*. Nothing in the data records a product, onboarding or campaign change around 1 July. That is the main open question for the product team.
- **Recommendation.** Treat "new-user paywall exposure within 30 days" and "30-day paid conversion by source" as leading indicators next to MAU. Find out what changed for new users at the start of Q3 before scaling paid_social further.

Scope, snapshot and definitions

Q2 = April–June 2026 and Q3 = July–September 2026, as complete UTC months. The run was independent: no investigation guides, answer keys, generator README or previous reports were read.

Item	Value
Database	`pockettoons.sqlite`, opened read-only. SHA-256 `8d39e78b…790b`, 713,474,048 bytes

Item	Value
Build	`3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8`, succeeded 2026-11-09 11:16:56 UTC; 122/122 reconciliation checks passed
Code	Repo commit `1fd5121`. The builder hash matches the build log. The registry text changed after the build, but only in documentation (no definition changed)
Coverage	2026-04-01 to 2026-09-30. Users and catalog are snapshots as of 2026-09-30 23:59:59Z
MAU	`mau` v1.1: distinct resolved users with a session touching the month. The quarter value is the **average** of the three monthly MAUs
Revenue	`net_revenue` (revenue group v1.1): successful charges minus refunds, booked at success, in exact cents. The quarter value is the **sum** of three months. "Net" means net of refunds only
Conversion	`paid_conversion_30d` (funnel and lifecycle v1.0): any successful charge within 720 hours of signup. The September cohort is not yet eligible

Layer choices.

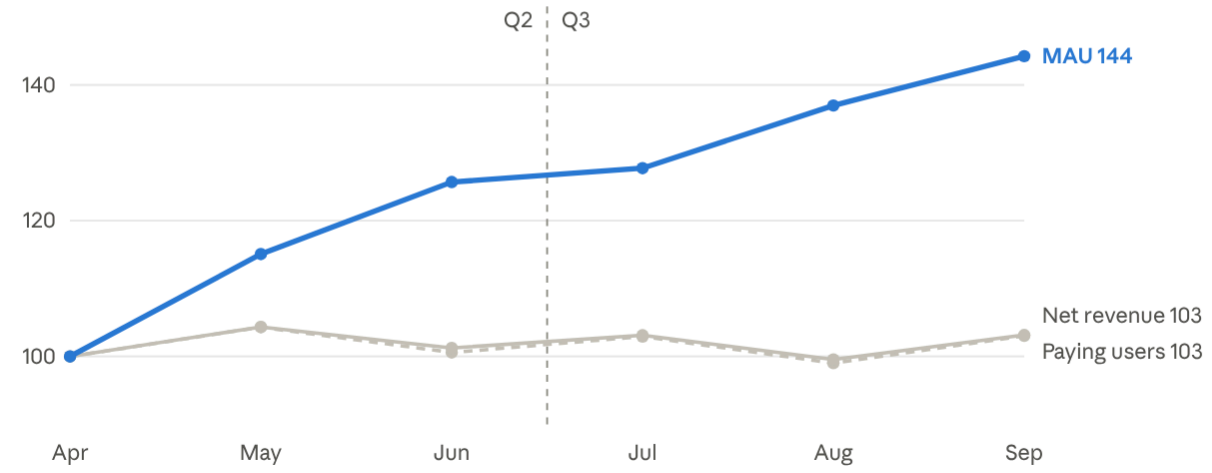
- **Gold** for every figure it fits exactly: monthly KPIs, revenue by type, growth accounting, cohorts, segments, the funnel and content. All of it is reconciled to the registry at build.
- **Silver** where Gold lacks the needed grain: conversion by source × cohort, exposure by signup period, and first-30-day behaviour. The by-source totals were checked against Gold in the same query and match exactly.
- **Bronze** only for raw audits that no higher layer holds: tier-change history and blocked-playback events.

Baseline: the premise holds

MAU grew 20% quarter over quarter while net revenue and paying users stayed flat

Quarter-average MAU +20.0% · quarter net revenue +0.07% (Q3 vs Q2 2026)

Index, April 2026 = 100



gold_kpi_monthly, build 3a0dbed2 · evidence q01, q02 · complete UTC months Apr–Sep 2026

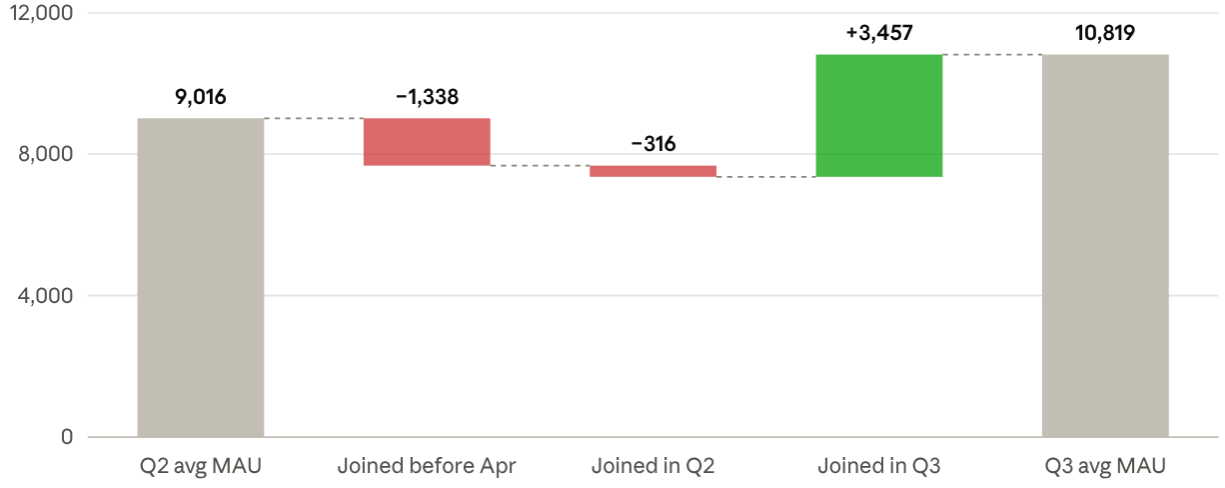
MAU rose every month, while net revenue and paying users stayed within 5% of their April level. Q2 net revenue was $30,145.00 and Q3 was $30,166.97. ARPU fell from $1.24 in April to $0.89 in September because the denominator grew and the numerator did not.

Decomposition: who the extra active users are

Users who joined in Q3 added 3,457 average MAU while earlier users fell by 1,654

Quarter-average monthly active users, Q2 to Q3 2026, by when the user signed up (groups partition MAU)

Green = users added, red = users lost, grey = quarter totals



silver_user_day_activity × silver_user_profile · evidence q12 (ties to gold_kpi_monthly MAU) · Q2 vs Q3 2026

The signup-period groups partition MAU, and the three steps net to exactly +1,803. Split by acquisition source instead (q06, also a partition), paid_social contributed +1,841, paid_search +92, unknown +25 and organic −156. Paid_social made up 64% of July–August signups, up from 24% in May. On the revenue side, paying users averaged 1,035.7 a month in Q2 and 1,036.0 in Q3. About 99% of gross revenue is the $9.99 subscription, so revenue tracks a subscriber base of roughly 1,000 that loses 9–11% a month and replaces about the same number.

Driver investigation

Nine hypotheses were tested over three rounds, which is the full budget. The process stopped once the gap was quantified: three are supported and six rejected.

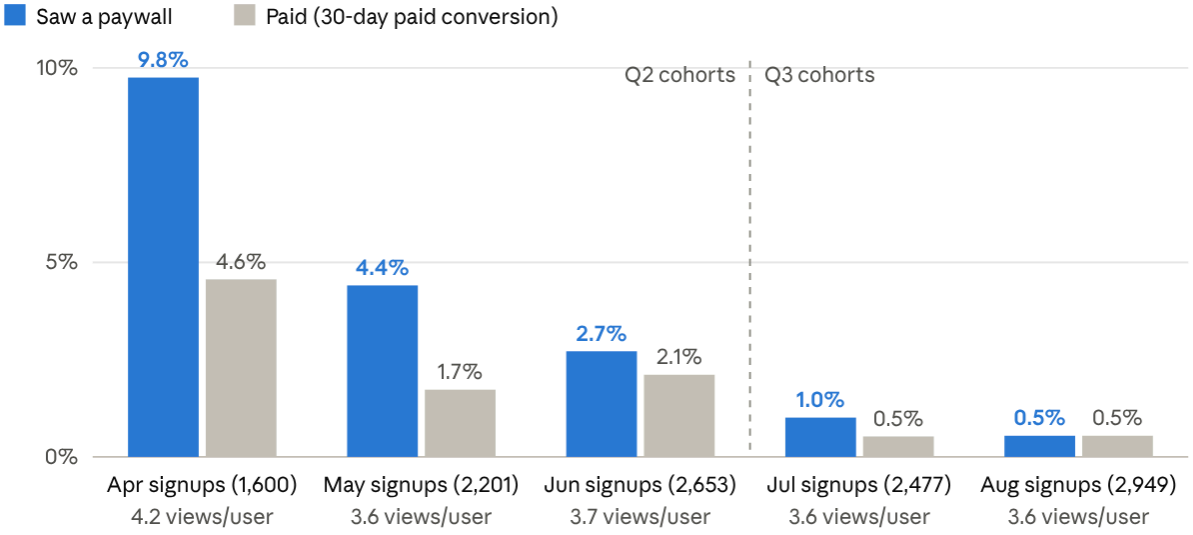
#	Hypothesis	Status	Evidence
H1	MAU growth comes from new, non-paying users	**Supported**	Paid_social users +1,841 of +1,803 (q06). Subscriber-status active users flat near 1,000 (q04). Users new in Q3 +3,457 (q12)
H2	Revenue per payer, mix, refunds or payment failures offset growth	Rejected	Subscription is 99.3% of gross at $9.99. Refunds were $37.93 in Q2 and $25.95 in Q3. Failure rate 5–6% in both quarters (q05)
H3	MAU growth is an artifact of one platform or country	Rejected	Growth appears on every platform and in every country (q06)
H4	The conversion drop is only a paid_social mix effect	Rejected	July–August conversion is about 0.5% within every source: organic 0.55–0.66%, paid_search 0.48–0.61%, paid_social 0.51–0.53% (q08)
H5	Paywall volume did not grow with MAU	**Supported**	Paywall views stayed at 1,023–1,088 a month from May to September. Exposure fell from 11.6% (May) to 9.2% (September) (q09)

#	Hypothesis	Status	Evidence
H6	New users rarely reach the paywall	**Supported**	Users who signed up in the same month saw almost no paywalls from June on (q10). Q3 signups had 0–1.3% monthly exposure versus about 15% for older users (q12). First-30-day paywall reach fell from 9.8% to 0.5% while viewing stayed flat (q14)
H7	Episodes moved from premium to free, removing paywall triggers	Rejected, immaterial	Only one episode changed tier, on 1 July (q13)
H8	Identity-resolution coverage changed MAU	Rejected	Unidentified sessions were 7.4–7.6% from May to September (q15)
H9	It is a paywall-tracking gap, not a behaviour change	Rejected	Payments fall in line with paywall views and checkouts. Blocked-playback events do not rise to fill the gap (q16, q08)

Arithmetic, not causation. The revenue identity is net revenue = paying users × ARPPU, and both terms stayed flat. Suppose the July–August cohorts (5,426 users) had converted at the May–June rate of 1.94%. That gives about 105 payers instead of 29: roughly 76 more subscriptions, or about $760 a month, which is about 2.5% of monthly net revenue. Even at Q2 conversion rates, a free-user MAU gain would move revenue only slowly. Revenue follows the subscriber stock, not the active-user count.

Q3 signups rarely reach a paywall: first-30-day reach fell from 9.8% to 0.5%

Share of each signup cohort in its first 30 days, 2026; viewing per user stayed near 3.6 views



April is inflated: the data starts with no subscribers, so the base forms that month. Compare May–Jun with Jul–Aug.

silver_user_profile, silver_paywall_funnel, silver_user_day_title_watch · evidence q07, q14 (conversion ties to gold_cohorts) · Sep cohort not yet eligible

Paywall reach fell first and furthest, and conversion fell with it. Viewing per user did not move, so new users are still using the product: they just stay inside the free experience.

Data quality findings

No data-quality issue changes the answer. Four things affect how the figures should be read.

Issue	Affected	Impact on interpretation	Handling
Data starts with no subscribers (0 at 1 April)	April: 937 paywall purchases as the subscriber base forms; April cohort conversion 4.56%	Inflates Q2 conversion and exposure baselines	Compared May–June with July–August cohorts, not April

Issue	Affected	Impact on interpretation	Handling
Unidentified sessions (no same-session user link)	2,286–3,703 sessions a month, 6.5–7.6% of sessions	MAU is a lower bound; the share is stable, so the QoQ change is unaffected	Reported, not imputed (`mau` v1.1 rule)
Reviewed raw payment corrections	13 payments (seven 100× unit errors, six non-numeric raw amounts)	None: curated `amount_usd` is used; raw feed never used for revenue	Listed in `silver_quality_exceptions`
Funnel links not captured	16–27 checkouts a month without a paywall link; 1–5 in-app purchases without a checkout link	Paywall-to-purchase rates slightly understated; too small to change exposure findings	Counted, not matched by time

Unexplained observation, not used for conclusions. Users who signed up in Q2 show about 290 paywall viewers in August and September but zero purchased paywalls (q12). In July they had 91. This pattern looks unusual and is worth a separate data review. It doesn't change the Q3-cohort finding.

Recommendations

1. **Find what changed for new users around 1 July.** Review release notes, onboarding, paywall placement and the paid_social landing experience. The drop appears in every source, so look for a product-wide cause first. *Validation:* first-30-day paywall reach should return toward the May–June level (2.7–4.4%).
2. **Add leading indicators next to MAU.** Track new-user paywall reach within 30 days and 30-day paid conversion by source each month. Both are computable from the existing Silver tables. *Validation:* a monthly dashboard where both indicators reconcile to `gold_cohorts`.
3. **Judge paid_social on payers, not active users.** Paid_social drove almost all of the MAU gain but produced 18 payers from its July–August cohorts. Compare spend with new payers (`gold_marketing_monthly`) before scaling it. That comparison was not run here.

4. **Test a paywall prompt for new free users.** One option is a prompt at the free-quota limit or on a premium episode. Run it as a controlled experiment, because this data shows association, not cause.

Limitations and evidence

- **Cause unknown.** The data shows where new users stop short of the paywall, not why. No product-change, release or campaign-content data exists in the fixture. Open question: did onboarding, paywall placement or the paid_social campaign change around 1 July 2026?
- **Synthetic data.** PocketToons is a synthetic fixture. Associations here are not causal proof, and real data would need the same checks.
- **Short window.** The September cohort has no complete 30-day window. Six months of history can't show long-run payback or LTV, which the registry lists as unsupported.
- **Ad hoc slices.** Conversion by source × cohort and first-30-day exposure use registry building blocks in Silver. They are labelled variants, not registry metrics. The by-source totals reconcile to Gold.
- **Not tested.** Marketing spend versus new payers, title-level paths to the paywall, and subscriber churn by signup cohort.

Evidence record. There are 16 queries (q01–q16), each run through the repo's `tools/evidence_query.py` against the read-only database. Each has its own JSONL log with the SQL, the SQL hash, the layer, the metric version, the row count and the truncation flag. All returned in full, and none were truncated. Elapsed time: question received about 11:47 UTC, first query 11:48:22, last query 11:50:33 UTC on 2026-11-09, plus report writing afterwards. The logs and an index with final hypothesis statuses are in the evidence bundle sent alongside this doc.